

Friends of Penelope

Volume Three



Editing, typesetting, and front cover by Ariadne Thompson
Contact: ariadnethompson@protonmail.com

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FOREWORD

ARIADNE THOMPSON

Memory is an echo that never quite fades. Memory is an oil painting forever being painted over. Memory is a reflection in turbulent water. Memory is sweet poison. Memory is the deepest root of the tallest tree. Memory is a shackle you cannot break. Memory is all you have. Memory is nothing but a bad joke. Here are nine works on the theme of memory. Will you remember me when I'm gone?

REMEMBERING US

R. W. MAXWELL

Do you remember the brush of fingertips as we shared smoke,
laughing together without needing to joke?
Do you remembering gaming from sun down to sun up,
boil the kettle, your turn, pour a cup?
Do you remember the play fights, any time, any place,
laying side-by-side, staring off into space?
Do you remember hushed voices when there was no one else home,
speaking private thoughts, being together alone?
Do you remember made-up song lyrics, and secret nicknames,
When everything changed we were always the same?

I remember the impulse and all the times we failed to quit.
I remember years of routine and the same old shit.
I remember the whites of your knuckles and the shaky patch-ups.
I remember one-sided conversations and the shut-the-fuck-ups.
I remember the punishing silences and the painful mind games.
I remember two people who just so happened to share our names.

HAUNTING HENRY

R. W. MAXWELL

The letter hadn't come.

Good. Still, What if it came tomorrow? What would he do?

No, Henry reminded himself. He mustn't keep worrying. Had to put it out of his mind. Put it aside. Out of sight, out of mind. As the saying goes. He could put away his letters, but tomorrow, the concerns would return. Tomorrow.

Henry folded every letter, returned them to their envelopes. Scraped off any wax residue into a hexagon-based brass ashtray on the corner of his desk. He stacked the envelopes in a wax paper lined shoebox that had once housed a pair of size twelve leather loafers from Marks and Spencers.

The shoebox, containing the letters within their envelopes, belonged on the top shelf of the closet, next to a white-and-black striped suitcase stacked beside a black-and-white streaked briefcase behind the box carts, the wooden step-ladder with the missing bracket, three full boxes of scrap paper labelled *Priority Three* in blue felt tip, an old yellow-stained pillow, a pair of skis, and a bucket of chewed-up dog toys.

Henry hesitated. What had he been looking for?

No doubt it would come to him.

Henry boiled water for tea on a stove-top kettle because it tasted better than the awful electric kettle water that kept all the hard minerals: magnesium, iron, who knows what else right there on the tip of his tongue. On the tip of his tongue. Something. A word. What was it? He could swear it had been right there. What was he forgetting?

Two prongs on the coat rack accommodated a reflective green pair of wellington boots hung to dry last spring when the fair field flooded. Was it last spring? Perhaps the spring before last? Walter hadn't minded the flooding. He'd chased the ducks for thirty minutes, then required one hour and twenty minutes drying down with a towel before being allowed back inside the house.

Henry preferred Tetley, no sugar, no milk, no nonsense, just teabag and water, if you'd be so kind. He accepted butter with his toast, but was just as happy to eat it with jam.

On Sundays, he completed the *Times'* crossword before noon or not at all. He never bothered with sudoku—waste of time. He'd known how to count since he was a child, so hardly needed practice

finding his way from one to nine. The crosswords were much more fun, but they had been getting harder. He rarely finished them these days. He ought to get a move on, if he was going to get today's finished. Oh, but he hadn't been out to get the paper yet, had he?

During the cold months, he welcomed Walter to sleep at the bottom of the bed, but not once the weather turned. Mid-spring to early-autumn nights were just too stuffy. Besides, Walter often woke up multiple times through the night for a scratch and Henry hated waking before his alarm.

Henry kept a phone on his bedside table. A landline. The only time it ever rang these days was because some robot wanted to ask him his personals. Still, he kept it there, next to the gold-based lamp on the bedside table in case of emergency. You never know when these mobile phones might just pack it in. You can't rely on new technologies to hold up when the going gets tough. They don't build things like they used to... used to be a matter of craft. A fellow would take pride in his work. Henry couldn't even tell you if it was a fellow making the bloody things any more. Probably another robot, moonlighting in the factory when it wasn't busy snooping about for his personals. No, he didn't need car insurance and thank you to not keep asking.

Sally was the driver. It was only right that she took the car with her. Henry hadn't put up much of a fuss about that. Walter would stay with him, of course. The house was still in both of their names. No rush to sell it yet, not while she was still travelling. How long had she been travelling now? One day, he knew the letter would come. A letter begging for his signature.

He'd have to check the letterbox. They might have already been delivered. Then, he could get a start on the crossword. Yes, he liked the crosswords.

Oh, but there's the crossword already on the desk. That's right, he picked it up earlier with the letters. Must have just slipped his mind. Now where was he?

Four across, seven letters: Irreconcilable. Initial first, grounds for, Edward Strange.

A MEMORY IN SILVER

ANDREW KARLYLE

Two people, TRADER and CUSTOMER, are bartering at the corner of a dirty cobbled street. One end is lit by sunlight, the other darkened with the shadows of trees.

CUSTOMER:

CUSTOMER produces a silver ring and hands it to TRADER.
'Ere, I found this ring along the road. What'll you give me for it?

TRADER:

Hmm. 'S nice. What road were that on?

CUSTOMER:

The one 'eading west, to Brambleford.

TRADER:

I know it. Quiet road that—treacherous.

CUSTOMER:

CUSTOMER shifts awkwardly.
Bit of rough terrain, ain't nothing if you know where you're going.

TRADER:

And what about the rough travellers? Any trouble?

CUSTOMER:

Nah. No trouble for my *blade*, at least.

TRADER:

A good blade is like a good friend. You must 'ave The Sweet Lady's blessing to be so lucky.

CUSTOMER:

The CUSTOMER becomes impatient.
Might be so, yeah. What about the ring?

TRADER:

Well, it's good silver with a nice rock... onyx, if I ain't mistaken, and the carved hands are really somethin'. Unique, even. Would make a right nice gift.

CUSTOMER:

I ain't givin' it away! I'm sellin' it for *coin*, so are you forkin' it over or am I goin' up the road to the next trader?

TRADER:

I'll give you somethin' for it, yeah. 'Old on.

CUSTOMER shifts and sighs with annoyance while TRADER rummages through a backpack.

I got a nice handful in here somewhere.

CUSTOMER:

What kind of trader ain't got a fistful of coins to hand?

TRADER:

TRADER turns to CUSTOMER, still reaching into the bag.
The kind who knows what your find is really worth, and is gonna give it ya.

CUSTOMER:

Before I die of old age, please.

TRADER:

TRADER pulls out a knife and swiftly stabs CUSTOMER.
Oh, definitely before that I reckon.

CUSTOMER:

CUSTOMER gurgles.
What—why the fuck—

TRADER:

'Why the fuck' is damn right. Why'd you kill 'em? See, I know that ring, I know the 'and it came from. I know—knew, I *knew* the person who wore it like it was a part of their own skin. The blood on your clothes, their hair on your boots, ain't no mistaken a killer when they're standing in front of ya.

CUSTOMER:

CUSTOMER groans with an and accusatory stare and an air of accusation.

TRADER:

No, I'm a world away from *you*. A knife in the guts of scum ain't *no trouble* for a decent citizen, but if everyone remembers me for killin' a killer, I couldn't ask for more. Not for me.

CUSTOMER:

CUSTOMER falls to the ground.

TRADER:

TRADER takes the ring from CUSTOMER and clutches it in bloody hands.
Not for me.

A PRAYER TO ERIS

BARBIE GORE

She's staring at me. Well, she doesn't know that I'm pregnant. Or that I'm a lesbian. She hopes I have a nice meal, isn't that nice, but she says that to everyone.

How would anyone even know? I remember I watched a documentary about magic years ago and it said the Ancient Romans used to cut open animals and read their entrails to divine the future. I forgot what it's called ¹. You could cut me open and find the little embryo inside me swimming around like a tadpole and you'd divine what I am. Or was. Which is pregnant.

What if I kept it?
I could completely
reinvent myself. I
could be one of those
smiling glowing
expectant mothers
from the adverts
lovingly stroking my
own belly. I could pick
my kid up from school
in my big SUV and
cry at their
graduation. I don't
want to do any of
that, but I also don't
want to have to walk
into my GP clinic and
ask for a referral to an
abortion clinic.

I'm aborting it, obviously, so nobody's
going to know. Except the abortion
doctor or whatever. But nobody I know
will know, so it'll be like it never even
happened. I wonder if it'd bother him
that I'm aborting his baby. His foetus.
His embryo. I mean, it is half him, right?
He left a vital piece of himself inside me
and it's mine now and I can extinguish it
and there's nothing he can do. It feels
delicious having this sort of power over
him. I wonder if it'd torment him,
knowing that I can destroy this part of
him. I watched an 18-rated horror movie
when I was twelve with a scene of a girl
getting impaled writhing around with her
guts spilling all around her. I bet he'd be
like that, writhing in bed, unable to sleep
or think or anything.

Does this make me a bad person? I think it's normal for a
lesbian to not want to be pregnant with a man's child though. And
I am a lesbian ². I'm still a lesbian. I've seen pictures of human
embryos online, they're just little squiggly seahorse things, it's not a
person. I can kill it and it doesn't matter. Even if it did matter, no
one knows. It's kind of gross that that thing is inside me. It's a

¹Editor's note: haruspicy

²Q: What do you call a pregnant lesbian?

A: Well first what you have to understand is that I'm really more of a
Kinsey 5.9, so...

miracle to think it could be a real person who thinks and talks and everything under the right circumstances. It's a gross miracle.

It's a mercy to abort it though, surely? It'd be cute as a child but it'd grow up and have to have its heart broken a thousand times.

Adulthood is the experience of forever being impaled through and through by horrible knowledge you don't want. I don't want to know that the rainforests are a coalpit and polar bears are melting and my country's entire history is building and operating the Brown People Suffering Machine. It hurts. It hurts to know. I should do my grounding exercises.

Five things I can see: a plate with a croissant on it. A mug. A cafeteria full of people. I think there's a pattern in how the ceiling tiles are arranged but I can't work out what it is. That girl with the piercings is kind of cute.

Four things I can hear: cutlery. Conversation. Somebody laughing. Buzzing fluorescent bulbs.

Three things I can feel: these jeans are too tight. I'm kind of nauseous, is that morning sickness³? I can feel the heat of my mug of coffee. I could smash this mug. I could just throw it as hard as I can against the linoleum floor right now for no reason and it'd smash into a thousand pieces and it'd feel so good. Cathartic. Coffee would splatter everywhere and a minimum wage cleaner would have to clean it all up and would hate my guts the entire time. Or maybe feel nothing. Or maybe feel the satisfaction of a job well done.

I don't want to have to make this decision. I don't know whether I'm a lesbian or whether I'm pregnant,

can't I just be nothing in particular? I have sex

with women sometimes and I might have

someone growing inside me. I'm an animal

grunting and squealing in the dirt. I'm

a girl writhing around helplessly

as my guts fall out. I'm sick

of this all. I just wish

something would push

me across the

edge so I could

strip off the

obligation

to care.

³Autoimmune conditions arise from a failure of the immune system to distinguish between self and non-self.

APPLE-STEMOLOGY

R. W. MAXWELL

I keep returning to a certain memory from my childhood. A memory about the beginning of uncertainty.

The beautiful three-storey Victorian house where I grew up lay caked in those cosy, greyish tones that we romanticise with the English autumn. Orange and brown leaves fell from the sweet chestnut and oak trees, blanketing the garden and hiding those vicious, spiky husks known among my classmates as nature's bastards. Rain specked the old windows, time-melted glass panes trembling in their draughty frames as the wind howled and the wooden floorboards creaked and groaned. The radiators moaned as mildewed pipes swelled and rattled back to work after a brief summer's respite.

As an adult, I've come to admire the autumn aesthetic, but as a child I found it boring. Autumn meant puddles, wind, and less daylight to play outdoors. Autumn was the time of year when the sun set before school was even over. So much of my time was wasted at school in those days. Precious playtime hours were squandered learning, a strange arrangement since I already knew everything—or at least I thought I did—until that fateful morning...

Still yawning, I paced down the stairs in my holey black socks. Mum, red in the cheeks and ever in a rush, paused before the kitchen door to demand that I hurry and put my school shoes on, then meet her by the front door.

She was gone before I had begun.

My eyes coated in sleep dust, I raised one hand to grip the wooden bannister, then lazily wiggled my foot into the dark mouth of my faded leather school shoe.

I felt the apple core with the tip of my big toe. Deep inside my shoe, the damp apple core rolled back and forth at my touch. The apple's recognisable texture immediately conjured a vision. I saw the yellowed flesh and darkening red skin around the tip where the twiggy stalk curved to one side. My mind's eye noted the gouge of teeth marks and the small black seeds just below the fading surface.

Surely, any one of the many pranksters in our household could have hidden the apple core inside my shoe. Even Mum, the most sensible of adults, wasn't beneath the odd playful joke every now and then. Last time my friend William stayed for a sleepover, she snuck up behind us while we watched a horror movie and jumped

out with a *boo!* We screamed like frightened lambs, then blushed like bruised fruit—come to think of it, I still hadn't gotten her back for that one.

And now I'd been pranked once more. I didn't yet know who, but someone had hidden an apple core in my shoe. That much was certain. The perpetrator might never reveal themselves... it was, perhaps, the perfect crime?

I rolled my eyes and reached for the apple.

Then it happened.

I was awake... alert to the tufty brown fur on my fingertips, the brush of whiskers against my palm, and the tickle of tiny claws over my thumb.

A mouse burst out of the dark confines of my shoe. It streaked across my wrist, then leapt from my arm.

I recall its face now, in that flash of a moment: the small grey-brown, fur-lined nose, the tufty, round ears, and the beady, black, excitable eyes. That brilliant little mouse was alive with the thrill of escape.

And I was unafraid.

I felt first surprise, then a dash of wonder.

I reached once more to retrieve the apple core, but was rocked then by a stark realisation. The apple core was gone. Lost.

I turned over my school shoe and shook it to dislodge any remaining possibilities. No apple core fell. No apple dropped. Nothing at all fell out of that shoe. Not a single thing dropped because the school shoe was already empty.

The apple core had never existed. My certainty vanished. My understanding vanquished, reality rewritten.

I had seen the apple core in my mind. I had felt its dampness. The tip of my toe had brushed the scoured ridges left by munching teeth. I had known the curve and stub of the stalk that stuck up from the reddening peak and trough. I had believed in the apple core. I had lived with the apple core. I had known the apple core, experienced it with the entirety of my earthly being.

And yet, by my own comprehension of cause and effect, there was no other explanation. What I had felt within my school shoe was nothing other than that thrilling little mouse. I had no alternative but to accept that... there never was an apple core.

I stared at the vacant darkness within the leather-rimmed black abyss of my everyday school shoe.

My mouth hung open.

My big toe twitched against the frayed thread of my simple black socks.

I suspected that nothing would ever be the same again.

Suspected, but daren't believe.

EXCERPTS - CHANNELLING WATER

MICA GILLARD

Here are a few excerpts from an experimental form text, the form of which lies somewhere between poetry and prose, with the understanding that the only fiction is the notion that the human imagination is in any way limited.

THE SHADOWSPEOPLE

There were those who opposed the freshwater and their daemons. They largely opposed them because they were themselves never able to conjure daemons. The shadowspeople were a group of spirits who loomed in the shadows of the fire and spoke with the dissenters, attempting to educate their ill-informed hatred.

Egra walked with Myrta along the grove of fruit trees that they had planted eight winters ago. This was their third fruiting year, and the clanspeople had enjoyed making preserves and eating the fruits.

"We have been here longer than we planned", Egra said solemnly to Myrtya, "perhaps it is time to move our people on."

"You speak as if the people are not their own agents. We are happy here Egra. What is the hurry to move?"

"We have become too comfortable. We must not forget the threat of the enemy is only just around the riverbend. They will find us, and they will destroy anything that we love. It is better to leave this place for the wilder ones to enjoy. Besides, you know the law: anyone who wants to cut their ties with the clan may do so at any time. If they wish to stay, they can. There is a brewing discontentment amongst the council of elders—"

"Well I may stay." Myrta declared abruptly and affirmatively. The idea stunned Egra. They had been companions and life partners for more than 30,000 moons, and the idea of separation was almost too much to bear. 'Why would you do that?' Egra asked, still reeling, ayer stomach flipping and doubling under the weight of imagining a separation.

"We are a people of our own will, just as you have said, and there's no use pretending like we are as we used to be. You speak of growing stale, but has that not happened to our love. We never set out to be companions for life. I love this land. My spirit is woven into the fruits and their seeds. You must see that."

To tell the truth, Egra had been so preoccupied lately with the mounting tensions within the council that ayer hadn't been offering much of her energies towards Myrta's projects. They were very independent in the daytime, and often only came together late at night, when the smog was more settled, and they could drink in each other's faces unmasked.

"Our primary reasons for being here: to create shelter, to maximise an area for carbon capture and biodynamic regrowth where the wild ones can thrive, have been achieved. It's time to go." Egra asserted firmly.

"Then you might have to let me go and leave me behind for real this time." Myrta spoke softly now, a tinge of something shaped like regret crossing her words like a shadow. Egra was so taken aback. Ayer was not used to this kind of dialogue with Myrta. She tried to think back to the last time they had been separated for more than a few days—it was hard to remember. Was this the right thing to do? Ayer wondered.

"My love, I feel so taken off guard by this news. Perhaps there are some unrecognised disputes to iron out before we speak of leaving each other in this land. Can we speak more on this tomorrow in the morning? I'll cancel my plans. For now I must go attend to the elders—I worry about the tensions that I sense are mounting in my absence."

Egra kissed Myrta on the forehead and swooped off with her dark wings into the shadowlands.

FRAGMENT FROM EGRA RAINE'S CONSCIOUSNESS JOURNAL

17.02.3002

I am a powerful witch remembering my purpose. All feeling is blue, all reminding, all remembering. Encased in amniotic sac I find myself amongst powerful company: water. The water reminds me that I am always coming home¹—I am never, never, never, alone.

14.03.3002

The crisis of our species is the collective forgetting of our paths and our purposes, this is becoming more and more obvious to me as the wheel of life turns and I find myself out on a limb, wondering whether you will ever come back to me. I am reminded of the need to breathe and move as slowly as is necessary.

¹Ursula Le Guin. Also my own poem (enclose at the back?)

III - WHO AM I?

I am not that guessing game where you ask “mammal?” “dead?” or “alive?”... I am the starseed of the breastmilk, but I could be lying. I could be telling you this to gain companionship, or better still, to chip you too. How do you know that you can trust me? What makes you think I won’t trick you? Perhaps you are too trusting. Or perhaps, you know who I am. Or at least you think you do. We shall see about that.

I tell the truth. I promise... I am the freshwater rising from the three thousand year old journey through rock—or so I say. How can you trust that I am what I say? How can you know I come from a place where we speak from the heart? I am telling you that I do. I hope you can decipher whether or not it’s right to believe me.

The truth is that I do not really exist. I am so real that I immediately cease to be tangible, nameable, fixed, or identifiable. I am floating amongst the amniotic fluid of your dreams. Seek and ye shall find. You’re unlikely to find me, but I hope (secretly) that you will try.

SCREENING OF CUSPS 32ND TRANSMISSION DIARY 334TH KESTA MEETING

I am overwhelmed by my past. I sit at my desk contemplating what I have done—what I have become... I used to think of myself as a strong and capable man; someone who had the world at his feet... and now I sit looking out of the window of Starship, my final Earth brainchild, wondering what my life was all for—and there’s nobody I can talk to here about this—nobody I can trust with my innermost world—hence why I am sitting here making these strange and possibly (or probably) fruitless diaries. I want to reach Earth again. It is true—I miss what I once despised. I was so quick—too quick, in my mind, to notice my body and how it was graced by the truth of the soil underfoot. The AI generated 5D printed stuff doesn’t reach my senses in the same way that Earth soil did. My wife and her friends, they love it here—AI generated children where you can choose the genetics to ensure there are no mistakes, like those evolutionary errors who remain back on Earth with the rest of the freaks—that’s one thing I don’t regret leaving behind: the genetic freaks of nature—they can stay and burn in the rubble for all I care. Our children are bred out of defects before they are even born—so finally we will create what the human race has always longed for: a perfect version of itself, free from defects, free from “minorities”. We are all the majority here and so there is no need

for competition. We enter the simulator and train ourselves out of any remaining imperfections that the genetic scientists didn't catch first time round—and so we are perfect, really, I couldn't ask for a better world—this is my dream come true... And yet my days are taken up more and more with gazing out of this stupid window and wondering what else is out there. I mean, where do we go from here? The Outerworld Space Life Team (OSLT for short) haven't found any other species to connect with, which frankly bores me. I am bored out of my mind... some days—the simulator... excites me, or at least it used to, but despite its perfection, something is, missing. And all my teams—none of them understand... I remain lost at sea in my mind. Not to matter, as I will prevail; we will prevail. Human coding, binary perfection, we will reach excellence! All hail the perfect human order.

Today I feel as though all doubts about Mission Mars were deluded fantasies of my past self; namely the fantasy that Life on Earth was ever worthwhile. All those human frailties, all these mismatched couplings that centred the false notion of love. Love is not real; all we have, all we have ever had is genetic coding and frailties as a result of these imperfect codes. It is time to claim back the Scientific truth and leave behind—no, abandon any false memories that were created by pure imperfect chemical synthesis: the chemical triggers of one person's body as pheromones, luring you, and all you thought you knew into a trap that we called Love. What I learned from my time on Earth is that there is no love, only business and self-interest. Some of the great Sci-fi writers of our past knew this—we all know this. Phenika paused the recording in disgust.

“Nearly 3000 years of evolution of Humankind and this is the man who though himself the pinnacle, worthy of a pedestal, how deluded.”

Ayer spat into the dust as if the Capsule recording head left a bad taste in ayer mouth. Then Mariska rose to speak:

“Kesta, fear not. It is true, in the grand scheme of things this, a child who imagines himself to be a man is little more than the dust in the torn nail of our great forebears—the Poets, the activists, our beloved Black Panthers—our beloved Malcom X, Audre Lorde, the sculptors, the witches. But did not all these people remind us that we must bear our burdens without complaint and rise to the challenge of witnessing the enemy in all their delusions for, yes, it is true that we must learn to love all beings that we cannot comprehend can bring us down. We must continue to watch these transmissions so that we may understand, or attempt to understand and get inside of, the logics ancestor's oppressor—for they chose to

leave with him. What hope was promised to them that they found on Mars that we cannot find here on Earth?"

Mariska's great wide eyes opened upon the crowded dimly lit room as if for the first time, their deep black gaze penetrating the part-body-souls of all those who looked upon her.

"The only thing," she continued, "getting in our way, is ourselves..." and with that she withdrew her great hulking form from the soap box-like stage and returned to the monitor at the side of the room to play the final part of the transmission.

IMPACT

ANDREW KARLYLE

Love isn't fleeting
Here now, gone tomorrow
Or next month, or next year
The impact is felt for millennia
And so my last act for you
Resonates
I abide by your will
And still
Returned to the Earth
You shall be
A love is not a drop
In the Ocean
It is a storm, torrential
A typhoon, exponential
It is the gift of worth
And you
You deserve it
Ten thousand fold

IN MEMORY OF MEMORY

NOVA RIDDLE

Blackout poetry featuring J. G. Ballard, Martin Luther King Jr.,
Dante Alighieri, and Susan Sontag.

Memories have dreams, in the dark
like shipwrecks on the sea bed.

In the End, we will remember the silence of

sadness is greater than memories of
pleasure . Everything remembered is
the past survived.

MAKING PEACE

VANESSA ATALANTA

To experience this piece of interactive fiction, please go to <https://vanessaatalanta.itch.io/making-peace> or scan the following QR code.



Friends of Penelope is a Norfolk-based writing club with members from across the UK and beyond. We are a collective of queer writers who are inspired by the worlds both inside and around us to capture unique moments of our lives, which *Friends of Penelope Volume Three* explores. The arts are often a reflection of real life and that leads many of us not only to the darker themes seen in some of the stories in this anthology, but also to the precious moments of hope seen in others.

We'd like to thank you for taking the time to read our third publication and supporting our contestants. We hope you enjoy our work.

Thank you to Anna Marie Clark for judging our competition, and special congratulations to R. W. Maxwell who won both first and second place! May there be many more winners to come.